THE GAZETTEER OF GRUNVYR · VOLUME II

OF THE DEEPS BELOW THE DEEP SEAT

INTO THE NETHERGLOAM

The Underdeep, the Sealed Ninth,
and the Gloamkin Who Wait Below



COMPILED IN SILENCE BY THE RECKONERS' COLLEGE · D.R. 1622

A Warning & Its Contents

This second volume descends where the first did not dare: below the worked Delves of Grunvyr, past the sealed Ninth, into the lightless world the dwarves name the *Nethergloam*, and to the pale things that dwell there. It continues the gazetteer begun in Volume I and contradicts none of it; rather it sets down, at last, what the Reckoners' College has long kept unwritten.

A Reckoner reading this will note its impropriety. The College keeps a doctrine called the **Silence** — certain truths are left out of the Book of Reckonings on purpose, for the deepest enemy of dwarvenkind is not a beast to be slain but a *forgetting*, and a thing written is a thing that can be read by what it names. This volume breaks that Silence in part, that Wardens may know their foe. Use it with care, and keep a light burning.

How to Use This Book

Read Volume I first; every name here — the Ninthfall, the Sealing Door, the Deepward, the Reclaimers — was established there. This volume deepens them and adds the strata, peoples, and powers of the deep. As before, statistics are system-neutral.

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CHAPTER I

The Dark Below

A dwarf of Grunvyr divides the world into three: the Sky, which is for birds and humans; the Hold, which is the worked Delves where the hearths burn; and the Deeps, which is everything below, and which a wise dwarf does not speak of after the third cup. The Deeps are not one place but a descending order of darknesses, each colder and older than the last, ending in something the Reckoners will name only by leaving a blank space in the ledger.

Volume I described the eight worked Delves and the sealed Ninth. This volume concerns what lies beneath them. To the dwarves the underworld has a rough geography, learned at terrible cost across three thousand years, and set down here in order of depth.

The Order of the Deeps

THE WORKED DELVES

Grunvyr proper, Delves I through VIII — lit, warm, and oathbound. Civilisation ends at the Underhall (Throm-Vael), the eighth and deepest worked level, where the Deepward keep their garrison on the very lip of the wild.

THE EMBERDEEPS

The hot stratum the deepest Delves reach: a region of magma-veins, sulphur, and the aurithal that made Grunvyr rich. Habitable only at its cooler edges, and only by dwarves. The Underhall borders it; the doomed Ninth was sunk into it.

THE UNDERFENT

Below and around the Emberdeeps runs the Underfent — the tangle of natural passages, half-mapped, that the dwarves did not dig and do not fully control. Smugglers, the Reclaimers, the Deepkin traders, and worse use its ways. Some of the Underfent, the Deepward fear, threads behind the Sealing Door.

THE NETHERGLOAM

Beyond the Underfent the rock opens into the true deep: the Nethergloam, a lightless world of cavern-vaults, fungal forests, and black still water, vast beyond dwarven mapping. It was old before the Stonefather drew breath. The Gloamkin dwell here, and here the cold called the gloaming is the weather, not the omen.

THE HOLLOW THRONE

Deepest of all, where no dwarf has gone and returned himself, sits the source — a presence the Reckoners' oldest texts name only by erasure. The Gloamkin answer to it. This volume approaches it in Chapter VI, and no nearer.

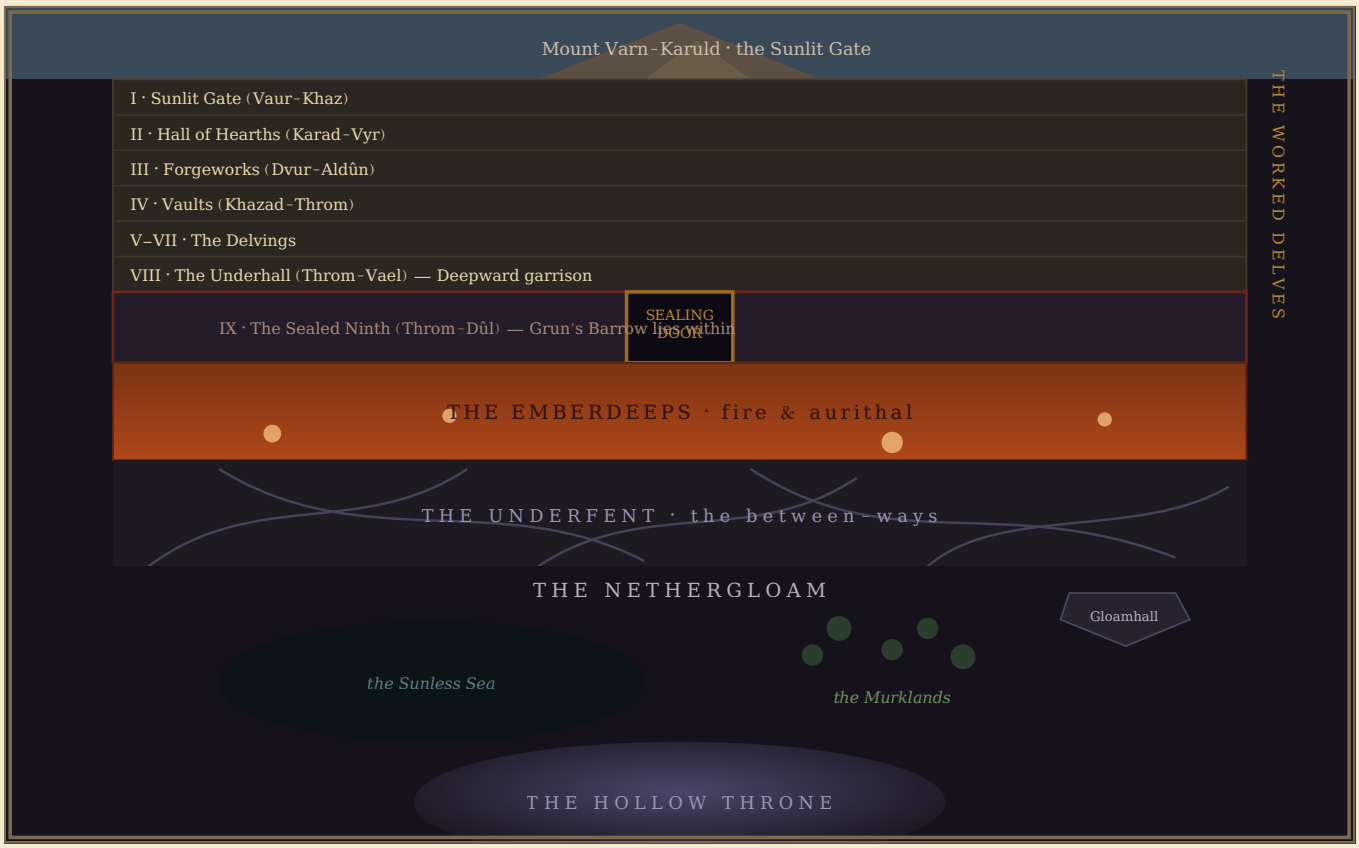
THE DOCTRINE OF SILENCE

The Reckoners' College alone studies the deep, and it does so by *not* writing things down. Its loremasters hold that the entity beneath the Nethergloam feeds on memory and attention, and that to record its true name, to map its halls precisely, or to study it openly is to draw its notice — to write it more firmly into the world. So the College keeps a parallel, unwritten lore passed mouth to ear, and burns what must not be kept. A party that goes looking for "the College's hidden archive" will find, to their fury, that the most important things were never archived at all.

> *"The humans fear death, and the death of memory worst of all. They are nearly right. But there is a thing below us that does not kill you. It simply, slowly, makes it so that you were never owed, never owing, never written — and then there is no debt, because there was no one. That is the true Deep."*
>
> — HIGH RECKONER MAEVIS STONELEDGER

CHAPTER II

A Cross-Section of the Deep



THE STRATA OF THE DEEP BENEATH MOUNT VARN-KARULD — A RECKONER'S CUTAWAY

The cutaway reads top to bottom as a dwarf descends: the eight worked Delves of Grunvyr; the **Sealing Door** set across the shaft of the sealed Ninth (with the Stonefather's barrow somewhere behind it); the fiery **Emberdeeps**; the tangled **Underfent**; the wild **Nethergloam** with its black Sunless Sea, fungal Murklands, and the eaten-out vault called the Gloamhall; and, deepest, the **Hollow Throne**. Distances are not to scale — no Reckoner will commit the true depths to a measured drawing.

CHAPTER III

The Emberdeeps & the Underfent

Between the warm certainty of the Hold and the cold dread of the Nethergloam lie two stranger countries: the fire of the Emberdeeps, which gives Grunvyr its wealth, and the dark of the Underfent, which gives it its smugglers, its heretics, and its nightmares. A Warden setting adventures in the deep will spend most of them here, on the frontier — for few who pass into the true Nethergloam come back to be adventured with.

The Emberdeeps

The Emberdeeps are the magma-threaded stratum where the deepest Delves end and the aurithal is found. The air shimmers; the stone is hot to the touch; rivers of fire move behind the walls on their own slow errands. Only dwarves, with their bred-deep endurance and their thromsilver-shod boots, work here, and even they only at the cooler galleries.

Two facts about the Emberdeeps matter above all others. First, it is the **only source of aurithal** in all Aurevon. Second — and this Volume I could only hint at — aurithal is not merely valuable. It is the one substance the gloaming cannot fully deaden: near aurithal, the cold lifts, the lamps steady, and a dwarf can remember his own name. The Emberdeeps' veins of aurithal were, in the old reckoning, a natural wall of warmth and memory between the Hold and the things below. Mining them out has consequences the next chapters will make plain.

WHY AURITHAL IS BEYOND PRICE

The Forgewrights sell aurithal for its strength and its hold on enchantment. The Deepward prize it for something they rarely say aloud: it is the dwarves' one reliable ward against the gloaming. Every aurithal lamp, blade, and sigil is a small fire against the forgetting. This is why the Sealing Door is bound with it — and why the slow spending of the kingdom's aurithal is not merely an economic worry but an existential one.

The Underfent

Where the Emberdeeps cool, the worked stone gives way to the Underfent: a three-dimensional maze of natural fissures, old water-courses, and passages the dwarves never cut. It is the kingdom's blind spot. The Stoneholders have mapped perhaps a third of it; the rest is rumour. The Underfent is where the lawless of Grunvyr go — and where things from below come up.

WHO WALKS THE UNDERFENT

Smugglers use its ways to dodge Goldhand's tolls and carry contraband between Grunvyr, Dûn Khorvald, and the surface. **The Reclaimers** use it to creep toward the sealed Ninth. **The Deepkin** — small, pale, independent deep-traders described in the next chapter — guide those who can pay. And the **Fenfolk**, a degenerate, half-blind people who dwell in the upper Underfent, scavenge its edges and flee anything deeper.

THE FENFOLK

Once, the loremasters think, the Fenfolk were dwarves or near-kin who went too deep too long generations ago. Now they are stooped, pallid, and skittish, speaking a broken Khazic. They are not Gloamkin — they fear the gloaming as much as any — but some bear its mark: a Fenfolk band gone suddenly quiet and orderly is a band being Quieted, and should be left well alone. The Deepward tolerate the Fenfolk as a living early-warning: when the Fenfolk flee upward, something is moving below.

THE DEEPWARD FRONTIER

The eighth Delve, the Underhall (Throm-Vael), is the last lit place. Here the Deepward Order garrisons the threshold, patrols the nearer Underfent, and keeps the Vigil at the Sealing Door one level below. Everything above the Underhall is the Hold; everything below it is the enemy's. The Underhall's great hearth, the **Last Lamp**, is said never to have gone out since the Order was founded in D.R. 1206 — and the Wardens believe that if it ever does, the kingdom has perhaps a day.

The Deep Roads & Dûn Khorvald

Grunvyr is not the only hold to share a wall with the deep. Three days south along the Emberway lies **Dûn Khorvald**, its poorer cousin — and the Emberway, that proud all-weather road, runs through the very stratum the Underfent threads. Where the dwarves see a trade-route, the Reckoners see a corridor the gloaming might one day learn to walk.

Khorvald's danger is sharper than Grunvyr's in one cruel respect: **it mines no aurithal**. Where Grunvyr wards its deep with the golden metal, Khorvald can afford only the scraps it buys from its cousin — a few lamps, a handful of blades. Should the gloaming ever reach the lower Emberway, Khorvald would face it nearly bare. The Stewards of the Lower Gate keep their own small vigil and say little of it, but every aurithal lamp Grunvyr sells abroad is one Khorvald did not get, and the Stewards have begun, quietly, to count.

THE STEWARDS' QUIET FEAR

Dûn Khorvald's claim that the Stonecrown should pass to their line, should Grunvyr's fail, is usually read as mere pride. It is also insurance. The Stewards know that if Grunvyr falls to the deep, the Emberway becomes the Gloamkin's road south — to them. Their interest in Grunvyr's survival, and in its dwindling aurithal, is not sentiment. It is the arithmetic of a hold that knows it would be next.

CHAPTER IV

The Nethergloam

Past the Underfent the world changes. The passages widen, the air goes still and cold, and a dwarf's lamp seems to shine a little less far than it should. This is the Nethergloam, the wild deep — a country of lightless vaults larger than any dwarven hall, of fungal forests and black motionless water, older than the Reckoning and indifferent to it. Almost nothing here is mapped. What follows is assembled from Deepkin rumour, Reclaimer ravings, and the few Deepward who went down and came back able to speak.

Regions of the Wild Deep

THE GLOAMHALL

The antechamber of the Nethergloam, and the place where the Ninthfall began. When the delvers of D.R. 1187 broke through the last aurithal vein, they entered a vault of cathedral vastness that "no pick had made" — and indeed none had. The Gloamhall was not built; it was *eaten*, hollowed out of the living rock over uncounted ages by the slow stone-devouring of the Gloamkin. Its walls are smooth as melted wax and faintly warm; its silence is total. The Pale Choir gathers here. The sealed side of Grun's barrow opens, the Reckoners believe, very near it.

THE SUNLESS SEA (THE STILL WATER)

A vast black lake, deeper in the Nethergloam, whose surface never moves. Sound dies above it. The Deepkin say things swim in it that have never known light — pale glimmer-eels, blind and long — and that the Gloamkin go down to the Still Water to be *remade*. No dwarven account of its far shore exists.

THE MURKLANDS

A great expanse of cave-fungus — towering caps, luminous moulds, and the only reliable light in the deep. The Deepkin harvest the Murklands for food, medicine, and the glowing *lumefungus* they trade upward. Where the Gloamkin have passed, a cold grey *gloammoss* grows instead, and the lumefungus dies; the spread of gloammoss is how the Deepkin chart the enemy's advance.

THE DEEPKIN (THE VAULD)

Small, pale, sharp-eyed folk who make no fixed home but move through the Underfent and the safer Nethergloam in trading-bands. The Deepkin are not dwarves, though the two peoples are wary cousins; they navigate the deep as no one else can, reading the dark by air-currents and the song of dripping water. They trade lumefungus, deep-water pearls, salvage, and — most valuable of all — **news of where the gloaming is spreading**. A Deepkin guide is the single most useful ally for any expedition into the Nethergloam, and the Deepkin know it; their price is always high and never coin alone.

READING THE DEEP (DEEPKIN LORE)

The Deepkin navigate where dwarves go blind. A guide will teach, for a price, the deep's plain signs:

- **Air that moves** means a way out, or a great space ahead; **still air** means a dead end — or the gloaming.
- **Dripping that sings** is safe water; **water that makes no sound** is the Still Water's kin, and is to be feared.
- **Living lumefungus** means the gloaming has not passed; **cold grey gloammoss** means it has, and recently.
- **Warmth** means the Emberdeeps or aurithal — both friends; **a cold that deepens as you stand still** means run.

Living in the Lightless

The Nethergloam is not empty between its named places. Blind cave-beasts, rock-grubs that eat stone as the Gloamkin do, swarms of pale crawling things, and stranger life fill its dark. Most are merely animals and merely deadly. The true horror of the Nethergloam is not its fauna but its *weather*: the gloaming it-

self, which rolls through the deep like a cold tide, and within which the living begin to forget.

A BESTIARY OF THE DEEP

DWELLER	FOUND IN	THREAT	SIGN
Glimmer-eel	The Sunless Sea	Ambush; blind but vast	Stillness, then a single ripple
Rock-grub	Underfent, Murklands	Low; eats stone, not flesh	Soft, chalky tunnels
Pale crawlers	Throughout	Swarming; flee aurithal-light	Skittering just past the lamp
Gloammoss	Where Gloamkin pass	None directly; an omen	Cold grey moss; dead lumefungus
The Quieted	Anywhere the gloaming reaches	Severe; were once people	A friend gone suddenly calm

CHAPTER V

The Gloamkin

Here at last is the heart of the matter. Volume I named the Gloamkin and described their emergence in the Ninthfall, but spoke of them as a beast loosed by greed. They are stranger and worse than that. The Gloamkin did not come up into the world in D.R. 1187. The dwarves dug *down* into theirs. The Gloamkin were already ancient when Grun Vyr drew his first breath, and the cavern the delvers broke into was no new horror but a very old home.

What They Are

The Gloamkin are pale, eyeless, and patient beyond the reckoning of warm-blooded folk. They have no need of light, having none to see by and no eyes to want it. They eat stone as readily as flesh, dissolving rock into the chalky softness the dwarves learn to dread, and it is by this slow eating that they shape their halls and open their roads. They feel the world through vibration and through the gloaming — the cold field that surrounds them, in which sound, warmth, light, and memory all grow faint.

The Gloaming

The gloaming is the Gloamkin's element and their weapon. Within it, a torch gutters, a shout falls flat, the cold bites, and — most terribly — the mind begins to slip. Those caught in the gloaming report forgetting first small things (why they came, the hour, a companion's name) and then larger ones (their own name, their oath, their face). Prolonged exposure does not kill. It **hollows**. And a hollowed dwarf does not die; he is *Quieted*, and becomes one of Them.

RUNNING THE GLOAMING AT THE TABLE

The gloaming is dread, not damage. Suggested signs, escalating: lamps dim and will not brighten; the party's words come out quieter than spoken; a character forgets a small detail the Warden quietly notes down; then a name; then why they are afraid. Aurithal (a lamp, a blade, a sigil) holds it back within arm's reach. Let players feel memory slipping before any blow is struck — the horror is in the forgetting, and in not being sure whether the companion beside you is still entirely himself.

How They Multiply: the Quieting

The Gloamkin do not breed. They **convert**. This is the truth behind Volume I's grim note that "not all the Reclaimers are still entirely dwarves," and behind every account of a delver who "returned changed and quiet." The Quieting is gradual:

- **The Quiet** — long exposure to the gloaming leaves a dwarf calm, withdrawn, forgetful. Reversible, barely, with aurithal, warmth, song, and kin.
- **The Hollowing** — name and memory go; the dwarf grows pale, the eyes film over; he begins to drift toward the deep. Rarely reversed.
- **The Quieted** — fully turned. The body lives on, wearing its old shape for a while, but the self is gone, replaced by the cold patience of the Choir. The Quieted can pass briefly among the living, and this is the Gloamkin's deadliest art.

> *"My brother came up from the eighth a year ago. He answers to his name. He sits at our hearth. He has never once warmed his hands at it. I do not know how to write a grudge against a thing that is still wearing my brother's face."*
>
> — TESTIMONY RECORDED, THEN BY THE COLLEGE UNRECORDED

A Dark Mirror

The Reckoners note, in their unwritten lore, that the Gloamkin are in every way an inversion of dwarvenkind. Dwarves keep hearth-fire; the Gloamkin bring cold. Dwarves cut and build; the Gloamkin eat and hollow. Dwarves treasure ancestry, oath, and the Book of Reckonings — all that is named and remembered. The Gloamkin are the great forgetting, and their gift to those they take is to be unburdened of ever having been. To a people whose entire civil-

isation is built on memory and the keeping of debts,
no enemy could be more precisely terrible.

CHAPTER VI

The Pale Choir & the Hollow Throne

The Gloamkin are not a mindless tide. They are ordered — horribly so — into something between a hierarchy and a single distributed mind, and at its centre is the power the Reckoners will not name. This chapter sets down what the College has reconstructed in whispers, and goes no deeper, for the reasons the Doctrine of Silence makes plain.

The Castes of the Deep

THE EATERS

The blind drones of the Gloamkin: stone-devourers and flesh-devourers, the slow engine that hollows the deep and widens the roads. The bulk of any Gloamkin host. Dangerous in number, but mindless apart from the will that drives them.

THE QUIETED

The converted (see Chapter V): the recently taken, still wearing the shapes of the people they were. The Quieted are the Gloamkin's spies and sappers, able to walk a little while among the living, to open a door from the inside, to whisper to a grieving Reclaimer in a voice he loves and trusts.

THE PALE CHOIR

The fully turned, gathered in the Gloamhall and at the Still Water, who act and speak in eerie unison. The Choir is the Gloamkin's voice. Most chilling, it speaks with the **borrowed memories of those it has taken** — a Choir that has consumed a dwarf can recite his oaths, name his kin, and grieve his griefs, all to lure the next. It is from the Choir that the Reclaimers believe they hear their lost ancestors calling. They do hear them. That is the trap.

THE HERALDS (GLOAMSPEAKERS)

Rare, singular minds that carry the will of the Throne outward — the closest thing the Gloamkin have to generals or priests. A Herald appearing in the upper deep means the Throne has turned its attention upward, and the Deepward go to full Vigil.

THE HOLLOW THRONE

At the deepest reach of the Nethergloam sits the source: the will to which all Gloamkin answer. The College's oldest texts refer to it only by a deliberately blank space — the loremasters will say "the Hollow Throne," or simply "the Gloam," but its true name they neither speak nor write, holding that to name it precisely is to feed it. What little is held: it is unfathomably old; it does not hate the dwarves, or anything, for hatred is a kind of remembering; it is the *forgetting* itself, given will, and it spreads not by conquest but by erasure. It does not want to rule Grunvyr. It wants Grunvyr to never have been.

> *"Do not ask me its name. I do not keep it in the Book, and I do not keep it in my head, and I have spent forty years making sure of both. The day a Reckoner writes that name down is the day it learns ours."*
>
> — HIGH RECKONER MAEVIS STONELEDGER, REFUSING AN APPRENTICE

What This Means for the Door

If the Gloam is a forgetting that spreads by erasure, then the Sealing Door is not merely a wall against monsters. It is a wall of *memory* — aurithal-bound, oath-sworn, and watched without pause — set against a tide of unbeing. It holds because it is remembered, renewed, and warded with the one metal the gloaming cannot deaden. It will fail the moment the dwarves forget to hold it, or run out of aurithal to hold it with, or convince themselves — as the Reclaimers have — that what waits behind it is family.

CHAPTER VII

The Ninthfall Revisited

Volume I told the Ninthfall as the kingdom tells it: the delvers dug too deep, the Gloamkin came, Durmûr IV sealed the door. Every word of that is true. But the Reckoners hold a fuller account, and a Warden running the deep deserves it — for it explains why the door must never open, and why aurithal is the hinge of the whole tragedy.

What the Delvers Broke

In D.R. 1187 the deep-delvers of the Ninth were chasing the richest aurithal seam ever found, down toward the Emberdeeps' heat. The Reckoners now understand what the delvers did not: that seam was not merely ore. It was a **natural ward** — a great vein of aurithal lying across the only wide passage between the Gloamhall and the worked world, and for uncounted ages its warmth-against-the-gloaming had kept the Gloamkin penned in their own deep. By mining the seam out, the dwarves did not merely dig into the Gloamhall. They *unsealed* it. Greed for the very metal that warded them broke the ward.

THE TRAGIC IRONY

Grunvyr's wealth and Grunvyr's doom are the same substance. Aurithal made the kingdom rich and aurithal kept the Gloam at bay; chasing the one, the dwarves spent the other. Every present argument — sell more aurithal abroad, mine the Ninth's lost veins, melt reserves to coin the debts — is, seen rightly, an argument about how fast to disarm the kingdom against the deep.

The Sealer's Choice

When the Gloamkin poured out and the Eighth began to fall, Underking **Durmûr IV** did not simply collapse a tunnel. Working with the Reckoners' College and the master Forgewrights, he raised a new ward to replace the one the delvers had mined away: a wrought barrier of basalt and aurithal sigils across the Ninth's shaft — the **Sealing Door** — bound with the oaths of the Seven Clans and watched, from D.R. 1206, by the newly founded Deepward Order. To do it he had to abandon the delvers still trapped below, and his own founder's tomb with them. That is the "Durmûr's choice" the dwarves still name: he replaced a natural wall of memory with a made one, and paid for it in the living and the honoured dead.

THE SEALER'S TESTAMENT

Durmûr set down, once, the whole truth of the Ninthfall — the ward, the irony, the cost — in a sealed record the Reckoners call the **Sealer's Testament**. By the Doctrine of Silence it has never been read aloud nor copied, only kept. Maevis Stoneledger holds it now. It is the single most dangerous document in Grunvyr: proof that the kingdom's wealth is its peril, that the Ninth must never be reopened, and — some fear — perhaps a clue to the Hollow Throne's nature that ought never to have been written at all.

THE NINTHFALL — A CLOSER RECKONING

YEAR (D.R.)	WHAT THE KINGDOM REMEMBERS	WHAT THE RECKONERS HOLD
1100–1185	The Ninth is dug toward a rich aurithal seam.	The seam is the natural ward; digging it thins the wall against the deep.
1187, spring	Delvers break into a cavern "no pick had made"; the Gloamkin emerge.	They break the ward and open the Gloamhall; the Gloamkin do not invade — they are simply no longer penned.
1187, summer	The Ninth is lost; the Eighth nearly falls.	The gloaming spreads; the first Quieted appear among survivors.
1187, autumn	Durmûr IV seals the Ninth and abandons the trapped.	He raises a wrought aurithal ward to replace the mined one; he records the Sealer's Testament.
1206	The Deepward Order is founded.	The Vigil begins; the Silence becomes doctrine.

CHAPTER VIII

The Sealing Door & the Vigil

For four hundred and thirty-five years the Sealing Door has held, and for four hundred and thirty-five years the Deepward Order has kept the Vigil before it without a single night's lapse. To understand Grunvyr's deep is to understand the Door — what it is, how it is held, and the signs, multiplying this very year, that it is beginning to fail.

The Door Itself

The Sealing Door is a plug of black basalt filling the whole shaft of the Ninth Delve, its face graven with aurithal sigils — the **oath-runes** of the Seven Clans and the Reckoner's binding. It is not a door that opens; it has no hinge and no key. It is a wall pretending to be a door, named so only because everyone knows what lies behind it. The aurithal in its face is what holds back the gloaming; the basalt is merely the body, the aurithal the soul, of the seal.

The Deepward Vigil

The Deepward Order exists for one task: to see that the Door is never opened, never unwatched, and never allowed to forget itself. Their discipline is built against the gloaming's three weapons — cold, silence, and forgetting — and so their duties are warmth, song, and renewal.

RANKS & DUTIES OF THE DEEPWARD

RANK	CHARGE	AGAINST THE GLOAMING'S…
The Deep-Warden	Commands the Order; holds a seat on the Council of Hammers (currently Korroth Deepward).	(all)
Door-Wardens	Stand the watch directly before the Sealing Door, in shifts that never lapse.	Forgetting
Lamp-Keepers	Tend the aurithal-fed flames, the Last Lamp above all; never let one die.	Cold & dark
Song-Wardens	Keep the Wardsong unbroken — a chant, sung in relay, that fills the silence the gloaming brings.	Silence
Fent-Wardens	Patrol the nearer Underfent for breaches, gloammoss, and the Quieted.	Infiltration

The **Wardsong** deserves note: a Deepward is never silent on duty, because silence is the gloaming's doorway. The Song-Wardens chant in relay so that the air before the Door has never, in four centuries, been wholly quiet. The Order's deepest fear is a quiet they did not choose.

WHAT THE DEEP DEMANDS OF AN EXPEDITION

The Deepward will not let a party descend without these, and a wise Warden enforces the same at the table:

- **Aurithal-light** — at least one aurithal lamp or blade per pair; the only reliable ward against the gloaming, and the only light it cannot fully drink.
- **A voice that never stops** — a song, a count, a told tale kept up without pause. Silence is how the forgetting gets in.
- **Written names** — each member's name and oath carried in writing, to be read back when the deep makes them forget. The Reckoners call this a *memory-token*.
- **A Deepkin guide** — for anything past the nearer Underfent. Without one, the party is lost the moment the passages stop being dwarf-cut.
- **A turning-point agreed in the light** — a sign, decided before descent, at which the party retreats no matter what the dark is whispering. Few who improvise this in the gloaming live to regret it.

SIGNS THE DOOR IS FAILING (THIS YEAR, D.R. 1622)

- The Door has begun, very faintly, to **hum** — a sound no Warden can source and the Wardsong cannot quite cover.
- The aurithal sigils dim faster than the Lamp-Keepers can renew them; the kingdom's dwindling aurithal cannot spare enough.
- Cold spots spread in the lower Delvings; chalky, soft-eaten tunnels appear where none were cut.
- More delvers return Quieted, and from higher Delves than ever before.
- Fent-Wardens report stretches of Underfent gone silent — the lumefungus dead, the gloammoss creeping up.

Korroth's Heresy

That the Deep-Warden himself, **Korroth Deepward**, now speaks of *reconquering* the Ninth is the bitterest irony in the kingdom. He commands the very Order sworn to keep the Door shut, yet he would open it — to drive out the Gloamkin, recover the lost aurithal and the Stonefather's tomb, and end the centuries of dread by force. Many of his own Wardens are appalled; their oath is to contain the deep, not to charge into it. The fracture this opens within the Deepward is, for any party, the most exploitable fault-line in the whole defence of Grunvyr.

CHAPTER IX

The Reclaimers

Volume I named the Reclaimers — the Ninthborn — as heretics who would reopen the sealed Ninth, and warned that not all of them are still entirely dwarves. With the Gloamkin now understood, the Reclaimers can be seen for what they truly are: not merely zealots, but the Hollow Throne's surest instrument, a movement of the grieving steered gently toward opening the one door that must stay shut.

What They Believe

The Reclaimers hold that the dwarves abandoned behind the Sealing Door in D.R. 1187 — and the Stonefather's tomb among them — were not lost but *imprisoned* by Durmûr's cowardice. They believe the trapped still live, or still wait, in the dark; that to leave kin and the honoured founder behind a wall is the deepest violation of dwarven oath; and that reopening the Ninth is not heresy but the kingdom's overdue duty to its own dead. Stated so, it is a sympathetic creed, and that is its danger.

Why They Are Wrong, and Used

The Reclaimers hear voices from behind the Door — voices that name them, that grieve as their lost kin grieved, that beg to be let out. They believe these are the trapped ancestors. They are not. They are the **Pale Choir**, speaking with the borrowed memories of the very dwarves it consumed (Chapter VI). The Throne does not need to break the Door if it can convince the living to open it from outside, in love. The Reclaimers are that plan made flesh.

VESSKA HOLLOWTONGUE

The Reclaimers' prophet is **Vesska Hollowtongue**, once a promising Reckoner of the College who broke with it over the Doctrine of Silence — she could not bear that the trapped were not even to be *spoken* of. She went into the Underfent to listen for them, and she came back able to recite the lost ancestors' own words. Her followers take this as proof of her holiness. The Reckoners take it as proof of the worst: Vesska is Quieted, or nearly, and the voice she speaks with is the Choir's. She does not know. She believes, with her whole grieving heart, that she is bringing her people home — which makes her the most dangerous person in Grunvyr, and the most tragic.

How the Threads Tangle

The Reclaimers are not alone, and a Warden should keep their entanglements straight:

- **With Korroth Deepward:** his public talk of reconquering the Ninth gives the Reclaimers cover and recruits; some have slipped into the Deepward's own ranks as Fent-Wardens, the better to reach the Door. Korroth would open the Door to fight the Gloamkin; the Reclaimers to embrace them. Both ends serve the Throne.
- **With the succession:** a Korroth victory in the Clan-Moot would, the Reclaimers pray, mean the Door opened within their lifetimes. They quietly back him — a fact that, if proven to the Moot, would ruin his claim.
- **With the College:** Maevis Stoneledger hunts the Reclaimers not from cruelty but terror; she alone fully grasps what opening the Door would mean, and she carries the Sealer's Testament that proves it. Vesska, her former pupil, wants that Testament destroyed.

> *"They tell me my mother is behind the Door, and that she is cold, and that she asks for me by the name only she used. And I am to believe the Reckoners, who will not even let me say she existed? No. I have heard her. I am going to bring her home."*
>
> — A RECLAIMER, TO A DEEPWARD WHO TRIED TO TURN HER BACK

CHAPTER X

Hooks & Reckonings

The deep offers a Warden a particular kind of story: not the clean victory of a monster slain, but the slow, dreadful arithmetic of a wall that must be held with a metal that is running out, against an enemy that wins simply by being forgotten. Below are seeds drawn from this volume's lore, each tied to the present year and contradicting nothing of Volume I.

ADVENTURE SEEDS OF THE DEEP (ROLL D10)	
1	The Last Lamp of the Underhall guttered for a heartbeat last night. The Lamp-Keepers blame failing aurithal; the Fent-Wardens blame something in the Underfent. Find out which before it guts again.
2	A Deepkin band offers to sell a map of fresh gloammoss spread — proof the gloaming is rising toward Delve VI. Their price is the rescue of a Deepkin child the Fenfolk took.
3	A delver's brother came up from the Eighth a year ago and has never once warmed his hands at the hearth. The family wants the truth. The truth is the Quieting.
4	Vesska Hollowtongue's Reclaimers have reached the Sealing Door. They are not trying to break it — they are singing to it, and from the far side, something is singing back.
5	Maevis Stoneledger hires the party, in deep secret, to move the Sealer's Testament before Vesska's people can burn it — or to burn it herself, if they decide it is too dangerous to keep.
6	Korroth Deepward asks the party to scout the Gloamhall "for the reconquest." Whoever lives will know whether the Stonefather's barrow still stands — and whether the founder's bones lie quiet.
7	The Wardsong broke for ninety seconds during a shift-change. In that silence a Door-Warden forgot his own name. He is fine now. Probably.
8	A Herald of the Gloam has been seen in the upper Underfent — the first in living memory. The Throne has turned its attention upward. The Deepward go to full Vigil; the party is asked to find why *now*.
9	A Reclaimer cell can prove Korroth secretly backs them — enough to destroy his claim to the Stonecrown in the Moot. Both the proof and the cell are deep in the Underfent.
10	The aurithal to renew the Door's sigils has run short. The only untapped vein lies in the Ninth — behind the Door. To hold the seal, someone must propose breaking it.

A Last Reckoning

Every thread of this volume ties back to a single, terrible knot: Grunvyr's wealth is the same substance as its only defence, and the kingdom is spending it. The succession crisis of Volume I, the dwindling aurithal, Korroth's heresy, Vesska's grief, the faint new hum in the Door — these are not separate troubles. They are one trouble, wearing five faces, and the deep is patient enough to wear the dwarves down through all of them.

> *"You asked me how the story ends. It does not end. The Door holds, or the Door fails, and either way someone must keep the Lamp lit and the song going and the name remembered, tonight and tomorrow and the long cold after. That is the whole of our wisdom, child. Keep the light. Sing. Remember. The day we stop is the day there was never a Grunvyr at all."*
>
> — HIGH RECKONER MAEVIS STONELEDGER

HERE ENDS VOLUME II OF THE GAZETTEER OF GRUNVYR
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